

Experience

Players earn **XP** (experience) from **battles** and completing **quests**.

<i>Level</i>	<i>XP Needed</i>	<i>Rewards</i>
LVL 0	0 XP	Path , 1 Talent Point, 4 Attribute Points , 5 Skill Points
LVL 1	200 XP +200 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 2	450 XP +250 XP	1 Talent Point, 2 Skill Points
LVL 3	750 XP +300 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 4	1100 XP +350 XP	1 Talent Point, 1 Attribute Point
LVL 5	1500 XP +400 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 6	1950 XP +450 XP	1 Talent Point
LVL 7	2450 XP +500 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 8	3000 XP +550 XP	1 Talent Point, 1 Attribute Point
LVL 9	3600 XP +600 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 10	4250 XP +650 XP	1 Talent Point
LVL 11	4950 XP +700 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 12	5700 XP +750 XP	1 Talent Point, 1 Attribute Point
LVL 13	6500 XP +800 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 14	7350 XP +850 XP	1 Talent Point
LVL 15	8250 XP +900 XP	2 Skill Points
LVL 16	9200 XP +950 XP	1 Talent Point, 1 Attribute Point

Balancing Act

Each encounter or resolved quest step rewards some XP to move the player towards the XP goal for that part of the story as well as items (like weapons or resources) that will help the player equip their party for the next encounter.

For example, in the first Act, the player should advance from LVL 0 to LVL 3, reaching LVL 3 right before they escape the Hand of Sorrow. This ensures that balancing Act 2 is easier: the player is assumed to be at least LVL 3, so enemies and skill checks can be adjusted accordingly.

The Goal of Balancing

The game should provide a consistent challenge to the player. Tactics should be important to defeating enemies in battle, and crafting should be a key part of the game, not an optional side-show.

Encounters should usually be achievable, and scale with the player's power. However, they should not automatically scale with the player's power, rather I think there's a power fantasy that is fulfilled by coming back to a boss you couldn't beat at a lower level and destroying them once you've acquired certain Talents or higher stats.

Seek to Achieve (most of the time)

- A consistent challenge for the player as they progress their characters up levels and equipment, culminating in a powerful party that can take on dangerous encounters

Seek to Avoid (most of the time)

- Clicking through endless mooks that have no chance against you
- Frequently fighting enemies that are far too powerful for you, who you have no chance against (even with great tactics)

Scaling

Since XP is based on encounters and not the enemies within them, **TODO**

Idea: Have a shorthand for XP, like 1 "story point"? And scale up the value of a story point later since XP is just a visual flair to give the good feeling of "number go up". AKA, a story point is worth 100xp at the beginning, but 1000xp later?

Character Systems

Each time a character levels up, they receive points to allocate towards some of their Attributes, Talents, and Skills.

Primary Statistics

Primary statistics are allocated directly by the Player.

Attributes

Attributes are inherent aptitudes of a character and significantly affect other character statistics. Attribute values start at 1. They are increased by spending Attribute Points.

<i>Attributes</i>	<i>Description</i>
Brawn	Physical strength and toughness
Agility	Speed, reflexes, and coordination
Wits	Intelligence and perception
Aura	Presence, willpower, influence

Level Modifiers

Level modifiers are different for each path.

<i>Modifier</i>	<i>Vanguard</i>	<i>Prowler</i>	<i>Artificer</i>	<i>Whisper</i>
Health	+7 / level	+5 / level	+5 / level	+4 / level
Mana	0	0	+3 / level	+5 / level

Base Values

Base values are different for each path.

<i>Base Value</i>	<i>Vanguard</i>	<i>Prowler</i>	<i>Artificer</i>	<i>Whisper</i>
Health	100	90	85	80
Mana	0	0	55	115

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Skills

Skills are situational, learned aptitudes of a character. They are learned or improved with *Skill Points*. Every Skill has five levels.

All Skills have five levels, of which 1-3 and 4-5 carries a bonus and may have different prerequisites to be unlocked.

BRAWN SKILLS

<i>Skill</i>	<i>Prereq.</i>	<i>Description</i>
Melee ¹⁻³	2 Brawn	+1 Melee Accuracy
Melee ⁴⁻⁵	4 Brawn	Heavy Weapons Proficiency
Berserk ¹⁻³	2 Brawn	+25% Melee Damage to low-health enemies +10% lose control
Berserk ⁴⁻⁵	4 Brawn	+5 Melee Critical Chance
Endurance ¹⁻³	2 Brawn	+25 Health
Endurance ⁴⁻⁵	4 Brawn	+5 Health Regeneration +5 R ^{SLASHING} +5 R ^{PIERCING} +5 R ^{BLUDGEONING}

AGILITY SKILLS

<i>Skill</i>	<i>Prereq.</i>	<i>Description</i>
Ranged ¹⁻³	2 Agility	+1 Ranged Accuracy
Ranged ⁴⁻⁵	4 Agility	+5 Ranged Critical Chance +10% recover arrows
Precision ¹⁻³	2 Agility	+1 Ranged Accuracy
Precision ⁴⁻⁵	4 Agility	+5% Ranged Damage
Evasion ¹⁻³	2 Agility	+1 Defense
Evasion ⁴⁻⁵	4 Agility	+1 Defense

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WITS SKILLS

<i>Skill</i>	<i>Prereq.</i>	<i>Description</i>
Tinker ¹⁻³	2 Wits	+10% recover a resource when crafting
Tinker ⁴⁻⁵	4 Wits	+10% craft an extra item
Medicine ¹⁻³	2 Wits	+10% Health restoration
Medicine ⁴⁻⁵	4 Wits	Unlock Poultice Recipe
Attunement ¹⁻³	2 Wits	
Attunement ⁴⁻⁵	4 Wits	

AURA SKILLS

<i>Skill</i>	<i>Prereq.</i>	<i>Description</i>
Inspiration ¹⁻³	2 Aura	
Inspiration ⁴⁻⁵	4 Aura	
Deception ¹⁻³	2 Aura	
Deception ⁴⁻⁵	4 Aura	
Ritual ¹⁻³	2 Aura	
Ritual ⁴⁻⁵	4 Aura	

Derived Statistics

These are allocated indirectly; they are determined by equipment, buffs, etc.

<i>Statistic</i>	<i>Abbr.</i>	<i>Description</i>
Health	H	Base survivability pool
Armor Rating	T	Armor
Attack	A	Improved chance to hit enemies
Defense	D	Improved chance to avoid physical attacks
Critical Chance	C	Chance to hit a critical
Critical Damage Multiplier	C ^M	Multiplier applied when a critical hit occurs
Guard	G	Temporary damage-absorption pool
Barrier	B	Temporary magical shield with a damage-absorption pool
Mana	M	Base casting pool

Attacking and Defending

Attacks are determined by rolling 2 six-sided dice and adding the attacker's Attack modifier. If the result is equal to or higher than the defender's Defense, the attack connects.

Damage Types & Resistances

There are several damage types. Physical damage types are the most common (slashing, piercing, bludgeoning).

Example

The PC has 10 piercing resistance and 20 fire resistance. A Syndicate enforcer attacks the PC with a Singing Strike. The attack applies 8 piercing damage and 5 fire damage.

- *Ignore Piercing Damage: $8 \times 10\% = 0.8$ (round up to 1)*
- *Ignore Fire Damage: $5 \times 20\% = 1$*

The piercing damage gets rounded up to 1, and the fire damage is 1.

The PC takes $(10 - 1 = 9)$ piercing damage and $(5 - 1 = 4)$ fire damage.

All resistances act the same way: by mitigating incoming damage as a percentage. Resistances are usually added by items.

<i>Statistic</i>	<i>Abbr.</i>
Slashing Resistance	R ^{SLASHING}
Piercing Resistance	R ^{PIERCING}
Bludgeoning Resistance	R ^{BLUDGEONING}
Fire Resistance	R ^{FIRE}
Cold Resistance	R ^{COLD}
Energy Resistance	R ^{ENERGY}
Poison Resistance	R ^{POISON}
Psychic Resistance	R ^{PSYCHIC}

Challenge Rolls

The way challenges are rolled, some situations in a battle may require a challenge roll. These rolls are made by rolling two six-sided dice and adding a relevant **Attribute**. There are a few modifications to this roll, depending on what the situation calls for.

- Circumstance bonuses or penalties may be added alongside the Attribute
- Rolling with advantage means one of the two six-sided dice is rolled twice, with the higher number being chosen
- Rolling with disadvantage means one of the two six-sided dice is rolled twice, with the lower number being chosen

The degree of success of a challenge roll is determined by comparing the result of the roll with a *target number*. The target number is provided at the start of the roll by the target of the roll, or the challenge being attempted.

<i>Result relative to the TN</i>	<i>Degree of Success</i>
Result ≤ -5	Critical Failure: You fail miserably and an additional, negative effect occurs.
-4 ≤ Result ≤ -1	Failure: You fail.
0 ≤ Result ≤ +4	Success: You succeed.
+5 ≤ Result	Critical Success: You succeed flawlessly and an additional, positive effect occurs.

Skill Check

Dialogue is more important to the player agency, and I want to avoid players getting frustrated during dialogue by failing a semi-random roll. Some dialogue options will be revealed based on a skill check (by showing the required skill and value in the dialogue option).

Choosing a dialogue option with a skill check *always passes*. There is no roll, the option is just available to them due to the skills they have allocated their points into.

Example

The PC has a Melee skill of 2 and a Medicine skill of 4. They're currently in a dialogue with a doctor who's asking for help treating an unconscious soldier who was injured in an encounter with a group of Husks.

Doctor Yovann: "I don't know if I have the supplies to treat him. There are more wounded on the way from the front, we're going to have to make sacrifices."

- [Medicine 2] Let me take a look. *Treat the infection*
- [Melee 2] We're going to need a tourniquet! *Slice off the infected tissue*

Companion Progression

Companions are leveled by the Player the same as the PC (Player Character). A default level-up option is also made available to automatically level-up along a predetermined path.

Characters in the *active party* will receive the same amount of XP as the PC, minus 2 XP.

Once recruited, any companion *not* in the active party will still level up. They will not gain experience as such, but if at any point they are two or more levels below the PC, their level will be adjusted to 1 below the PC's.

Tinkering

- All paths: Poultices, poisons
- Vanguard: Disposable Armor (provides Guard and resistances)
- Prowler: Ammunition (arrows), and *potent* poisons
- Whisper: Totems (to cast spells safely)
- Artificer: Elixirs (disposable buffs), gadgets (reusable buffs, disposable debuffs)

Talents

The four paths are **Vanguard**, **Prowler**, **Whisper**, and **Artificer**. Since up to level 16 there are ~9 Talent points available to the player, I think there should be about three times as many Talents (30) for the player to spend points on.

Of the 30 Talents in a tree, 15 points will be shared with another path, leaving 15 unique Talents for a chosen path.

Planning process: Write 100+ talent name ideas down, pick 20 to make generic, then split the other 80+ up into different paths.

1. ~~Brainstorming; Write down interesting ability names from games; Sonny, Grimwild, Dragon Age: Origins, Fallout, Skyrim~~
2. Determine Roles
3. Distribute Roles to Paths using a point system (30/Path) to also determine the budget for what kinds of Talents will be allocated to each Path
4. Assign a budget system to prevent power creep (what “power” of Talents will be available)
5. Design Talent templates

Path Roles

- **Damage:** Dishing out any form of damage to enemies
- **Survivability:** Absorbing or avoiding damage
- **Healing:** Keeping yourself and others alive
- **Buff/Debuff:** Helping your allies and hindering your enemies
- **Tinkering:** Your crafting ability outside of battle

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Talent Name Brainstorming

According to Plan	Educated	Kindred Spirits	Ritualist
Adrenaline Rush	Enrage	Lethality	Scattershot
Aegis	Epiphany	Life Giver	Second Wind
Aim	Expertise	Lightning	Sharpshooter
Alchemist	Explorer	Lightning Reflexes	Shatter
Anchorshot	Familiar	Lurker	Shepherd
Animal Companion	Fast Metabolism	Maelstrom	Shield Wall
Animalism	Favored Enemy	Mark of Death	Silent Running
Arcane Recovery	Fearsome	Mighty	Skullduggery
Arcanist	Finesse	Mind Blast	Slash
Assassination	Fireball	Mind over Matter	Smite
Assault	Flesh Wounds	Mind Seed	Spelleater
Automatons	Flurry	Muffle	Stonefist
Awaken	Free Will	Oak/Stone/Iron -flesh	Tactician
Backstab	Frenzy	Oathsworn	Taunt
Bash	Friendly Face	Opportunist	Tempest
Bastion	Fury	Opportunist	Tenacity
Battle Cry	Got Your Back	Overkill	Terrify
Below the Belt	Grenades	Overpower	Tether
Blessed	Guardian	Panache	Threaten
Break	Haste	Pinning Shot	Tumultuous Mind
Bulwark	Healer	Placebo	Uncanny Dodge
Challenge	Healing Hands	Poisoner	Verdant Whispers
Channel	Herbalism	Power of Blood	Visions
Cleave	Heroic Defense	Predator	Vital Strike
Control	Heroic Offense	Primordial Bonds	War Cry
Counterspell	Hex	Protocol	Warborn
Courage	Hunter	Pummel	Warsongs
Dauntless	Hunter's Mark	Rage	Wayfarer
Deadly Aim	Hymn	Rapid Reload	Weapon Mastery
Decimate	Immobilize	Rapid Shot	Weapon Sweep
Destroy	Incinerate	Reader	Weasel
Devout	Indomitable	Rebuke	Wild Shape
Dirty Fighting	Intense Training	Reconstruct	Wilder
Discipline	Into the Fray	Relentless	Windcall
Disengage	Iron Will	Rend	Winter's Grasp
Disrupt	Jack of All Trades	Restore	Wisps
Doctrine	Judgement	Revival	Wound
Dynamic Entrance	Keen Senses	Riposte	Wrath

Combat

Conditions

Conditions are common Effects applied during combat.

Off Guard: You are distracted from your defense. You get -2 Defense when attacked.

Threatened: You are threatened by a particular individual on the battlefield. If you attack anyone besides this individual for the duration, you will become *Off Guard* for 1U.

Stunned: You are incapacitated. You cannot act. You are automatically *Off Guard*. If this stacks, you are incapacitated for an additional turn.

Slowed: You lose one Action on your next turn. If this stacks, you lose an additional action.

Vanguard

"Stand behind me, now! No retreat!"

You are a heavily armored, frontline protector. You're most comfortable standing firmly between your vulnerable companions and the sharp points of enemy weapons.

Features

The Vanguard is all about protecting allies and interrupting enemies' attempts to control the battlefield.

Any Path can have Guard (because items provide it), but Vanguard's naturally receive Guard equal to 20% of their Health, automatically making Guard a core mechanic.

Guard	Threaten	Retaliate
A temporary shield that absorbs physical damage before it reaches Health.	You attack <i>threatened</i> (by you) targets if they attack someone who isn't you.	Punish enemies for attacking allies or breaking your Guard.

Pillars

Scale my Guard · Sustain my Guard · Control the Battlefield · Survive

Vanguard Talents

<i>Talent Name</i>	<i>Pillars</i>	<i>Cost</i>	<i>Description</i>
Shield Bash	Control	●●○ 1U	Deal light damage, and <i>threaten</i> an enemy, with a chance to stun the enemy
Challenge	Control	●●○ 1U	<i>Threaten</i> one enemy for 1U
Intercept	Control	●●○ 3U	<i>Protect</i> an ally for 1U, when they are attacked, you take the damage instead
Aggressive Tendencies	Control	Passive	Enemies that attack your allies have a small chance of being threatened.
Brace Yourself	Sustain Guard	●●○ 6U	Your Guard gains 50% physical resistance for 1U
Defensive Stance	Survive, Sustain Guard	●○○ 3U	For 1U, your Guard gains increased resistance, and you cannot be stunned. When you are attacked, you gain a small amount of Guard (up to your max)
Heavy Armor Training (2)	Scale Guard	Passive	Gain more Guard from heavy armor. Guard gets a little more physical resistance
Steadfast	Survive	Passive	+5 Health/Level, Raise the Guard from health ratio by 5%
Elemental Conditioning	Survive	Passive	Gain 25% Resistance to any one element

Prowler

“They passed this way, I’m sure of it.”

You’re an expert hunter and thrive at range. Your enemies are your prey, and you stalk them relentlessly, striking at their weak points. You’re accompanied by a fiercely loyal animal.

Features

The Prowler is all about taking down enemies at range with consistent, high damage attacks.

Prowlers have a companion animal, which appears with them during combat and widens the Path’s tactical scope.

Hunt	Avoidance	Companion
<i>Mark</i> an enemy as <i>Hunted</i> . You deal extra damage to Hunted enemies.	You do your best to avoid enemy attacks and opt for hit-and-run tactics instead.	Your companion provides you with additional tactical options.

Pillars

Target Pressure · Avoid · Execution · Companion Benefit

Prowler Talents

<i>Talent Name</i>	<i>Pillars</i>	<i>Cost</i>	<i>Description</i>
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Pressure	●●○ 1ℳ	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Pressure	●●○ 1ℳ	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Pressure	●●○ 3ℳ	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Avoid	Passive	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Avoid	●●○ 6ℳ	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Avoid	●○○ 3ℳ	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Execution	Passive	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Companion	Passive	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet	Companion	Passive	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet

Whisper

Artificer